Bhindranwale. Allegations surfaced that the person in the footage was the CM himself. Summoned, Mann appeared before the Akal Takht on January 15 and described the video as an AI manipulation. According to the Takht, he was asked to nominate a forensic lab to examine the footage but failed to do so. The institution subsequently sent the video to two labs recognised by the Centre, which reportedly concluded that the footage was authentic. Delivering the verdict, Gargaj said that Mann had lied before the Akal Takht and questioned his fitness to take decisions in the interest of the Sikh community.

Mann has refused to accept the findings. In a video statement the following day, he reiterated that the individual in the footage was not him, arguing that the forensic reports did not establish who the person was. Going further, he described the Takht's present office-bearers as political appointees serving their "political masters" and accused them of building a false narrative to malign him. AAP's Punjab media in-charge, Baltej Singh Pannu, was blunter, calling the verdict a conspiracy orchestrated by the Badals and Gargaj a "pawn" of the Shiromani Akali Dal.

Takeaways

- **A disputed video prompts Sikh clergy to direct the community not to associate with CM Bhagwant Mann**
- **Mann rejects the verdict, accusing Akal Takht office-bearers of serving their "political masters"**

That line of attack represents a significant departure from past confrontations. Punjab's politicians may challenge decisions of the Akal Takht, but most have ultimately performed penance rather than question the legitimacy of those delivering them. Mann had been moving in that direction for some time. Earlier this year, he publicly questioned the "fairness" of Gargaj's appointment, describing it as inconsistent with Sikh *maryada* (religious code and tradition). The friction, therefore, predates the disputed video.

THE LAW OF CONTENTION

It also extends beyond it. Beneath the immediate controversy lies the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026, Punjab's new anti-sacrilege law. The Akal Takht argues that the legislation was passed without adequate consultation with Sikh institutions despite objections conveyed through the assembly speaker. Historically, both the Centre and the Punjab government have generally consulted the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) on laws affecting Sikh religious affairs, reinforced by the 1959 pact between prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru and Akali leader Master Tara Singh. Mann, in turn, has accused the religious leadership of a volte-face, noting that those who once sought an anti-sacrilege law are now rejecting it.

The confrontation is unfolding on unfamiliar ground. In the past, the Akali Dal stood as the principal vehicle of Panthic politics. Today, it has been weakened by electoral decline and internal divisions. New claimants have moved into the space, most notably Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh, a jailed Khalistan sympathiser whose Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) is seeking to expand its influence ahead of the 2027 election.

AAP, which came to power on promises of governance and reforms, now finds itself drawn onto this terrain shaped by religious identity. The danger is that periods of uncertainty within the mainstream Panthic order have often brought unpredictable political consequences and heightened security concerns in Punjab. ■

▶ MANIPUR

A Fresh Fault Line

Three years after violence erupted, a new Naga-Kuki divide threatens to redraw Manipur's conflict map

By **Hrijoy Das Kanungo** and **Keny Phurailatpam**

FOR MORE THAN THREE YEARS, THE DOMINANT NARRATIVE of Manipur's conflict has revolved around the Meitei-Kuki divide that erupted on May 3, 2023. It split the state between the Meitei-dominated Imphal Valley and the Kuki-dominated hill districts of Churachandpur, Kangpokpi and Pherzawl, leaving hundreds dead and thousands displaced. The Naga-majority districts of Senapati, Ukhrul, Tamenglong, Kamjong and Noney stayed largely untouched.

Not principal participants, Nagas, along with the Muslim-Pangal community, were among the few who could move across territory held by both sides. That neutrality began to crack in early 2026. Tensions between Nagas and Kukis in Kangpokpi, Senapati and parts of Ukhrul have opened a fresh front. Abductions, retaliatory violence, blockades and fresh displacement show the crisis is no longer confined to the old fault line.

THE FEBRUARY SPARK

The first signs appeared on February 7, after a reported drunken brawl between Kuki and Naga men in Ukhrul's Litan Sareikhong village. Localised clashes followed across the hill districts. Sources estimate nearly 20 people were killed in separate incidents in the early days of the violence. The situation deteriorated sharply on May 13, when three Thadou (Kuki-Zo sub-group) church leaders and